

T-TESS Observation Prep Kit

Your Complete Guide to Earning "Distinguished" on Every Domain

Part 1: Domain-by-Domain Breakdown with Distinguished Indicators

Domain 1: Planning

What Appraisers Look For

Planning is evaluated based on your lesson plans, unit plans, and the evidence that you designed instruction intentionally.

The Scoring Continuum

Level	What It Looks Like
Improvement Needed	Plans are incomplete, lack alignment to standards, or show no differentiation
Developing	Plans align to standards but are generic; limited differentiation
Proficient	Plans are standards-aligned, include clear objectives, and address diverse learners
Accomplished	Plans reflect deep understanding of standards, data-driven adjustments, and strong differentiation
Distinguished	Plans are exemplary — student-centered, data-driven, cross-curricular, and responsive to individual needs

🌟 Distinguished Indicators — What Sets You Apart

To score Distinguished in Planning, your appraiser needs to see:

- ☐ **Data-driven design:** You can point to specific student data that informed THIS lesson's design
- ☐ **Individualized adjustments:** Plans include specific accommodations by name/group (not just "ELL students will...")

- ☐ **Cross-curricular connections:** Lessons intentionally connect to other subject areas
- ☐ **Student voice in planning:** Students had input on learning activities, topics, or pace
- ☐ **Vertical alignment:** You reference what students learned before and where they're headed
- ☐ **Anticipation of misconceptions:** Plans document common student errors and how you'll address them
- ☐ **Multiple assessment types:** Plans include formative, summative, and self-assessment opportunities
- ☐ **Real-world relevance:** Clear connection to students' lives, interests, or future applications

Pro Tips for Domain 1

1. **Annotate your lesson plans** — add margin notes showing WHY you made each choice
 2. **Reference data explicitly** — write "Based on Unit 3 results showing 60% struggled with fractions, this lesson..."
 3. **Include student names** (in your personal copy) — "Javier and Maria need sentence stems" shows individualization
 4. **Show your planning process** — save drafts that show how plans evolved based on data
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Domain 2: Instruction

What Appraisers Look For

This is the "during the lesson" domain. Appraisers observe how you deliver instruction, engage students, and adjust in real time.

The Scoring Continuum

Level	What It Looks Like
Improvement Needed	Teacher-centered lecture; students passively receive information
Developing	Some student engagement but mostly teacher-directed; limited questioning
Proficient	Good mix of strategies; students are engaged; questioning goes beyond recall
Accomplished	Student-centered instruction; high-level questioning; real-time adjustments based on student responses
Distinguished	Students drive the learning; instruction is seamless and responsive; every student is challenged at their level

★ Distinguished Indicators

- ☐ **Students lead learning:** Students explain concepts to each other, ask their own higher-order questions
- ☐ **Seamless differentiation:** You adjust complexity, pacing, or support for different groups without stopping the flow
- ☐ **Real-time data use:** You visibly check understanding and modify instruction on the spot
- ☐ **Higher-order thinking is the norm:** Students analyze, evaluate, and create — not just remember
- ☐ **Academic vocabulary is student-owned:** Students use content vocabulary naturally in discussions
- ☐ **Multiple modalities:** Visual, auditory, kinesthetic learning happening simultaneously
- ☐ **Technology enhances (not replaces):** Tech is used to deepen learning, not just for engagement
- ☐ **All students are challenged:** GT students have extensions; struggling students have scaffolds — during the same activity

Pro Tips for Domain 2

1. **Plan your questions in advance** — write 3-5 higher-order questions on your lesson plan
2. **Use a visible formative assessment** — whiteboards, thumbs up/down, or quick tech poll during the lesson
3. **Have a "pivot plan"** — if 50%+ get it wrong on the mid-lesson check, what will you do?
4. **Let students talk more than you** — aim for 70/30 student talk to teacher talk

Domain 3: Learning Environment

What Appraisers Look For

The physical and emotional environment of your classroom. This is evaluated from the moment the appraiser walks in.

The Scoring Continuum

Level	What It Looks Like
Improvement Needed	Disorganized, off-task behavior, tense atmosphere
Developing	Basic organization; teacher maintains control but compliance-based

Proficient	Organized, positive climate; students follow routines; mutual respect evident
Accomplished	Student-centered environment; students take ownership; strong community feel
Distinguished	Students self-manage; classroom is a learning community; students hold each other accountable

Distinguished Indicators

- ☐ **Student self-management:** Students transition, get materials, and start work WITHOUT teacher direction
- ☐ **Peer accountability:** Students respectfully redirect each other when off-task
- ☐ **Student-created environment:** Word walls, displays, or rules were created BY students
- ☐ **Flexible use of space:** Students choose where/how to work based on the task
- ☐ **Visible learning goals:** Students can articulate what they're learning and why
- ☐ **Celebratory culture:** Student achievements and growth are publicly celebrated
- ☐ **Restorative practices:** Conflicts are handled through dialogue, not just consequences
- ☐ **Inclusive environment:** Every student has a visible place and voice in the classroom

Pro Tips for Domain 3

1. **Data wall** — display class growth data (anonymized) where students can see progress
2. **Student jobs/leadership** — assign meaningful classroom roles that students rotate
3. **Procedure anchor charts** — created WITH students, posted visibly
4. **Flexible seating** — even if you can't buy furniture, offer choice in where students sit/work

Domain 4: Professional Practices & Responsibilities

What Appraisers Look For

This domain is evaluated holistically across the year, not just during observations.

The Scoring Continuum

Level	What It Looks Like
Improvement Needed	Minimal participation in school community; poor communication; no growth efforts
Developing	Meets basic requirements; attends required PD; communicates when prompted
Proficient	Active participant; regular parent communication; pursues relevant PD
Accomplished	Leader among peers; proactive communication; seeks growth opportunities beyond requirements
Distinguished	Transforms school culture; mentors others; leads professional learning; advocates for students and profession

★ Distinguished Indicators

- ☐ **You lead PD:** You've presented to colleagues, led a PLC, or facilitated campus training
- ☐ **Active mentoring:** You formally or informally support other teachers' growth
- ☐ **Proactive parent engagement:** You contact families with POSITIVE news, not just problems
- ☐ **Committee leadership:** You don't just serve on committees — you lead or significantly contribute
- ☐ **Professional advocacy:** You participate in district-level work, policy discussions, or community outreach
- ☐ **Continuous learner:** You pursue professional growth beyond what's required (conferences, certifications, reading)
- ☐ **Student advocacy:** You actively participate in ARD/504/LPAC meetings and advocate for student needs
- ☐ **Reflective practitioner:** You can articulate your growth areas and what you're doing about them

Pro Tips for Domain 4

1. **Keep a communication log** — every parent email, call, or conference noted with date
2. **Document PLC contributions** — save agendas where YOUR name appears as presenter/contributor
3. **Volunteer for visible roles** — lead a campus initiative, mentor a new teacher, present at a staff meeting
4. **Pursue one meaningful PD** — a book study, conference, or certification that you can discuss authentically

Part 2: Pre-Observation Planning Template

Complete This Before Your Scheduled Observation

TEACHER: _____
DATE OF OBSERVATION: _____
CLASS/PERIOD: _____
SUBJECT/GRADE: _____
UNIT: _____
APPRAISER: _____

LESSON OBJECTIVE(S):
What will students know or be able to do by the end of this lesson?
Standard(s): _____

Objective in student-friendly language:
"I can _____"
"So that I can _____"

DATA THAT INFORMED THIS LESSON:
What student data did you use to plan this specific lesson?

Assessment/Data Source: _____
What it showed: _____
How it shaped this lesson: _____

LESSON FLOW (with approximate times):

Warm-Up/Hook (____ min):

Direct Instruction/Mini-Lesson (____ min):

Guided Practice (____ min):

Independent/Group Practice (____ min):

Closure/Exit Ticket (____ min):

DIFFERENTIATION PLAN:

For struggling learners / SpEd / ELL:

For on-level learners:

For advanced / GT learners:

HIGHER-ORDER QUESTIONS I'LL ASK:

(Plan at least 3 questions at Bloom's Analyze level or above)

1.

2.

3.

4.

FORMATIVE ASSESSMENT:

How will you check understanding DURING the lesson?

What will you do if students DON'T understand?

What will you do if students master it quickly?

THINGS THE APPRAISER SHOULD KNOW:

(Context that affects the lesson – student situations, schedule changes, co-teaching arrangements, etc.)

MY GOAL FOR THIS OBSERVATION:

What specific T-TESS indicator am I trying to demonstrate?

Evidence the appraiser should look for:

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Part 3: During-Observation Checklist

What to Have Visible and Ready When Your Appraiser Walks In

Classroom Environment (Check Before They Arrive)

Physical Space:

- ☐ Room is clean and organized
- ☐ Student seating is intentional (groups, pairs, or arrangement that matches the lesson)
- ☐ Learning objective is posted and visible (written in student-friendly language)
- ☐ Agenda/schedule is posted
- ☐ Word wall is current and relevant to the unit
- ☐ Anchor charts are visible and student-referenced
- ☐ Student work is displayed (recent, high-quality, diverse students represented)
- ☐ Data wall or growth tracking visual is displayed (class or individual — anonymized)
- ☐ Materials are pre-staged and ready (no fumbling during the lesson)
- ☐ Technology is tested and working

Documents Ready for Appraiser:

- ☐ Lesson plan (printed copy for appraiser) with TEKS alignment highlighted
- ☐ Seating chart with student names
- ☐ Any relevant IEP/504 accommodation notes (for appraiser context)
- ☐ Data that informed this lesson (printed or on screen)
- ☐ Previous assessment results showing why this lesson was needed

During the Lesson — Mental Checklist

Instruction:

- ☐ Start with an engaging hook (not "open your books to page...")
- ☐ State the objective clearly — have students repeat or rephrase it
- ☐ Use multiple modalities (visual, auditory, kinesthetic)
- ☐ Ask higher-order questions (use your pre-planned questions!)
- ☐ Wait time — pause 3-5 seconds after asking a question
- ☐ Call on multiple students, not just volunteers (use equity sticks, cold call)
- ☐ Use academic vocabulary and require students to use it
- ☐ Monitor student work while circulating (don't sit at your desk)

- ☐ Provide specific feedback ("Great job identifying the main idea" not just "Good job")
- ☐ Adjust instruction if students look confused (this shows responsiveness!)

Student Engagement:

- ☐ Students are talking more than you
- ☐ Students are working collaboratively at some point
- ☐ Students can explain what they're learning and why
- ☐ Students are using academic language
- ☐ ALL students are engaged (check corners, back row, quiet students)

Differentiation (Visible):

- ☐ Different tasks/scaffolds for different levels
- ☐ Sentence stems, graphic organizers, or supports visible for ELL/struggling students
- ☐ Extension activities available for early finishers/GT
- ☐ You interact with students at different levels during independent work

Assessment:

- ☐ Formative check during the lesson (whiteboards, thumbs, poll, partner share)
- ☐ Exit ticket or closure activity at the end
- ☐ You reference or collect data from the formative check



Timing

- ☐ Lesson starts on time (bell-to-bell instruction)
- ☐ Transitions are smooth (under 2 minutes)
- ☐ Pacing is appropriate (not rushed, not dragging)
- ☐ Closure happens BEFORE the bell (not cut off by dismissal)

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Part 4: Post-Observation Reflection Template

Complete This Within 24 Hours of Your Observation

TEACHER: _____
 DATE OF OBSERVATION: _____
 DATE OF POST-CONFERENCE: _____

OVERALL REFLECTION:

How do you feel the lesson went overall?

WHAT WENT WELL (cite specific evidence):

1. _____
Evidence: _____
2. _____
Evidence: _____
3. _____
Evidence: _____

WHAT I WOULD CHANGE:

If I taught this lesson again, I would:

1. _____
Because: _____
2. _____
Because: _____

STUDENT LEARNING EVIDENCE:

Did students meet the lesson objective?

- ☐ All/most students met it
- ☐ About half met it
- ☐ Most did not meet it

How do I know? (What evidence?)

Exit ticket/assessment results:

- % of students who demonstrated mastery: _____%
- Common misconceptions observed: _____
- Next steps for students who didn't master it: _____

DOMAIN-BY-DOMAIN SELF-REFLECTION:

Domain 1 (Planning): How well did my plan serve the lesson?

Rating: ☐ IN ☐ Dev ☐ Prof ☐ Acc ☐ Dist

Notes: _____

Domain 2 (Instruction): How effective was my delivery?

Rating: ☐ IN ☐ Dev ☐ Prof ☐ Acc ☐ Dist

Notes: _____

Domain 3 (Learning Environment): How was the classroom climate?

Rating: ☐ IN ☐ Dev ☐ Prof ☐ Acc ☐ Dist

Notes: _____

QUESTIONS FOR MY APPRAISER:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

GROWTH GOAL:

Based on this observation, one thing I will intentionally work on before my next observation is:

Action steps to get there:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

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Part 5: Evidence Documentation Log

Track Every Piece of Evidence You Collect

Use this log to track what evidence you've saved, when you saved it, and which T-TESS domain it supports.

Date	Evidence Description	Domain(s)	File Location	Notes
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Evidence Count by Domain

Domain	Target	Current Count
Domain 1: Planning	8-10 pieces	_____
Domain 2: Instruction	8-10 pieces	_____
Domain 3: Learning Environment	6-8 pieces	_____
Domain 4: Professional Practices	8-10 pieces	_____

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Part 6: Self-Scoring Rubric for Each Domain

Score Yourself Before Your Appraiser Scores You

Domain 1: Planning — Self-Score

Indicator	IN (1)	Dev (2)	Prof (3)	Acc (4)	Dist (5)
1.1 Standards alignment	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
1.2 Data-driven design	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
1.3 Knowledge of students	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
1.4 Activities/resources	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Domain 1 Average	_____				

My strongest indicator: _____ My growth indicator: _____ Evidence I have for my

strongest: _____ Plan to improve my weakest:

Domain 2: Instruction — Self-Score

Indicator	IN (1)	Dev (2)	Prof (3)	Acc (4)	Dist (5)
2.1 Achieving expectations	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2.2 Content knowledge	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2.3 Communication	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2.4 Differentiation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2.5 Monitor & adjust	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Domain 2 Average _____

My strongest indicator: _____ My growth indicator: _____

Domain 3: Learning Environment — Self-Score

Indicator	IN (1)	Dev (2)	Prof (3)	Acc (4)	Dist (5)
3.1 Classroom environment	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3.2 Managing behavior	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3.3 Classroom culture	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Domain 3 Average _____

My strongest indicator: _____ My growth indicator: _____

Domain 4: Professional Practices — Self-Score

Indicator	IN (1)	Dev (2)	Prof (3)	Acc (4)	Dist (5)
4.1 Professional growth	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4.2 School community	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4.3 Family engagement	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4.4 Compliance & ethics	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Domain 4 Average _____

My strongest indicator: _____ My growth indicator: _____

Overall Self-Assessment Summary

Domain	My Score	Target Score	Gap
1. Planning	_____	_____	_____
2. Instruction	_____	_____	_____
3. Learning Env.	_____	_____	_____
4. Prof. Practices	_____	_____	_____
Overall Average	_____	_____	_____

Am I on track for my TIA goal? ☐ Yes ☐ Getting close ☐ Need to improve

My top 3 action items:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____